

“Limit Situation”

Exploring Inner existentialist dilemma in the Virtual Space

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Figure 1: Pictures from the exhibition of the works

ABSTRACT

"Limit Situation" is a virtual reality artwork that explores the universal existential dilemma of human existence through immersive and narrative-driven virtual spaces. The artwork is divided into six chapters of virtual spatial experiences, inspired by six books that provide background and context. These virtual experiences create a realm for emotions and contemplation. From conceptual to tangible, from real to virtual, the artwork represents the artist's understanding of existential dilemmas.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Human-Centered Computing; • Philosophical Aspects; • Arts and Humanities; • Cultural Aspects;

KEYWORDS

Virtual Reality, Immersive Experiences, Existential Psychology, Storytelling

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1 INTRODUCTION:

Created during the outbreak of the global COVID-19 pandemic in 2022, "Limit Situation" delves into the prevalent rise in global anxiety and depression, with WHO reporting a 25% increase in the first year of the pandemic.[Brunier and Drysdale, 2022] While uncertainty and fear of the pandemic played a part, this era's pressures in aspects such as life, education, and employment have also contributed. Beneath the public health crisis lies an overlooked crisis of societal spirituality.

A psychology professor from Peking University has indicated in their research that an increasing number of individuals are suffering from "Hollow-Heart Disease." [Ge and Ownby, 2021] Students across different stages may encounter profound feelings of loneliness and a sense of meaninglessness, perceiving life as devoid of value and purpose.[Ge and Ownby.] This isn't a psychological ailment cured by medication, but a deeper lack of values and belonging. The underpinning of various hollow and restless psychological phenomena is fundamentally tied to existential questions.

Amidst the surge of online information, accelerated pace of life, promotion of success ideologies, consumerism, and societal alienation from labor, human existence becomes increasingly instrumental and detached.

In existential philosophy, a "limit situation" refers to a challenging and pivotal moment in one's life, where the individual becomes acutely aware of their mortality, vulnerability, and the limitations of human understanding within that context.

Within a limit situation, individuals contemplate matters closest to their core. Utilizing numerical sculptures, virtual reality scenes, and visual imagery, the artwork constructs an experience of existential introspection. The VR scenes narrate a journey from 1 to 6, where each facet of the cube leads to symbolized and artistic

depictions of human circumstances. The abstract digital space resembles an endless realm of the mind, with six paradoxes reflecting humanity's inescapable predicaments.

Link to the full introduction of the work:
<https://www.ziyaolin.net/limit-situation>

2 VR SCENE SETTING:

The introductory Scene 0 features the central visual of a "God's Die," inspired by Einstein's quote "God does not play dice" – implying the universe adheres to deterministic laws rather than probabilistic rules. Quantum mechanics, however, shattered this notion, leading to a philosophical upheaval. Starting with the question of whether God rolls dice, this scene initiates a journey of existential paradoxes.

Scene 01's main visual is both a door and a maze, symbolizing potential beginnings, endings, or transitions to the unknown. The misty maze unveils its path only upon reaching the end. From the God's-eye view, the word "Certainty of Uncertainty" forms the maze's route. This scene dialectically examines the inevitability behind seemingly random life steps.

Scene 02, "The Future of Past," features an abstract sculpture representing time. The circular design embodies cyclical time, with the longest second hand piercing through time slices, emphasizing the significance of every moment. Inspired by the book "Einstein's Dreams," [Lightman, 2011] which interprets time through thirty dreams, this dreamlike space portrays "The Shape of Time" through off-screen narration, where viewers explore stories hidden in meteorites across the vast cosmos.

Scene 03, "The Choice of No Option," suspends a geometric heart without ventricles. From a specific angle, the segmented pyramid resembles an empty heart, metaphorically portraying an era's emptiness. Chinese paradoxical phrases originate from interviews, such as "Elegant Vulgarity," "Lively Loneliness," "Perfect Regret," and "Weak Strength." Intricate lines depict complex mental states, reflecting the perpetual choice-making and being chosen that shape each person's multidimensional identity.

Scene 04, "The Beginning of the End," presents a conical sculpture symbolizing a mountain encircled by feathers. The feathers, light and irrelevant, contrast the monumental task of pushing a massive stone toward the other side of the mountain, even though it remains a mountain. This scene parallels the myth of Sisyphus [Camus, 2013], illustrating an absurd and rebellious narrative.

Scene 05, "The Solvable of Inexplicable," features a monument symbolizing human civilization, inscribed with the "Standard Model," [Shivni, 2016] humanity's closest approximation of universal principles. This digitized, symbolic, and formulaic space highlights the difficulty of finding meaning in a completely numerical universe, where equations governing everything showcase the paradox of understanding the universe's intrinsic incomprehensibility.

Scene 06, "The Death of Birth," depicts melting hands and a decreasing countdown of numbers from three billion. A human heartbeats approximately three billion times in a lifetime. From birth, humans embark on a countdown towards death. In the final scene, all that remains are melting hands, flickering countdown, and fading heartbeats. Birth, aging, sickness, death, change, and passing are integral to life. While birth has no inherent purpose,

humans strive to imbue existence with meaning throughout their brief decades.

3 CONCLUSIONS

"Limit Situation" is an experimental exploration of the human psyche within a virtual universe. Bridging literature, philosophy, and psychology, it transcends mere VR technology exploration to focus on narrative and contemplative aspects. Players, through immersive virtual experiences, can listen to their inner voice and ponder their limited circumstances. The existential predicaments of every person living in this world are genuine and inevitable. Each individual has faced or is facing a limit situation. As philosopher Jaspers stated, The origin in the Limit Situation brings the basic motivation to fight. [Fuchs et al., 2013] Throughout life's uncertainty and contradictions, humans seek meaning and purpose, and this artwork is dedicated to everyone who battling their own predicaments.

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